

AMAZON RAIN FOREST

Covering an area the size of Australia, the Amazon rain forest is the largest remaining tropical rain forest anywhere on Earth. It covers about one-third of South America, mostly growing around the Amazon River in Brazil. Many animals, birds, insects, and reptiles rely on the trees for food and shelter, as do the tribes of Amazonian Indians who have lived in the forest for thousands of years. But the rain forest is a fragile environment and both wildlife and people are under serious threat as vast areas of the forest are cut down.

Native Indian homelands

This village chief is from the Temb  tribe.



INDIAN TRIBES

At one time there were about 5 million native Indians living in the rain forest; today, only about 220,000 remain. The largest of these tribes are located on the above map. Most live as shifting cultivators, which means they settle for a while to hunt and grow basic food crops, and then move on. This way the forest soil can recover its fertility. Since the arrival of people from outside the forest, the Indians have been at risk from diseases, such as influenza and measles, to which they have no resistance.



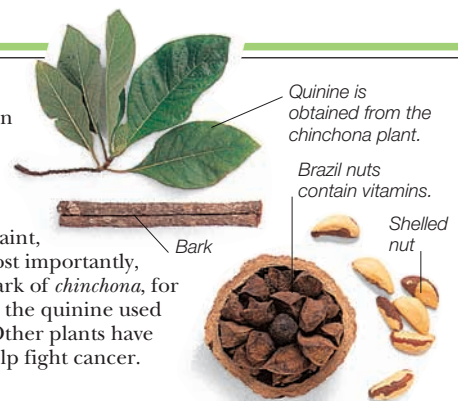
MINING

In the last 20 years large deposits of gold and other minerals have been discovered in the Amazon rain forest. At Carajas, a huge iron mountain was accidentally discovered when a geologist crash-landed his helicopter. The rock contains massive amounts of iron ore, as well as manganese and copper. Mining is one of Brazil's major industries, despite the damage it does to the rain forest.



PLANT POWER

The forests contain plants that provide the basis for many valuable products, such as rubber, varnish, paint, cosmetics, and most importantly, medicines. The bark of *chinchona*, for example, supplies the quinine used to treat malaria. Other plants have properties that help fight cancer.



LOSS OF FOREST

Vital areas of forest are lost through logging, cattle ranching, and relocation (moving people). Building roads also opens up the interior to further destruction. If the present rate of deforestation continues, there will be no forest left by the end of the century.

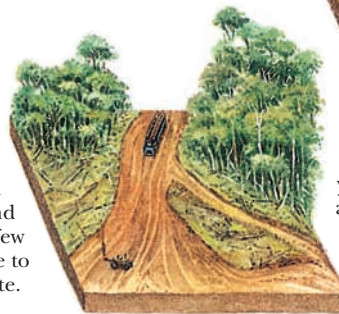
RELOCATION

The Brazilian government recently cleared large areas of forest and encouraged landless people to buy small plots of land for farming. But the soil is shallow and rapidly loses its fertility.



CATTLE BREEDING

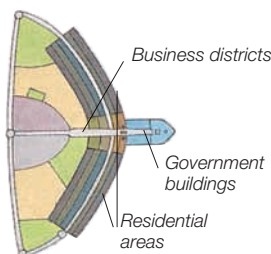
About 30 percent of Brazil's rain forest has been cut down for cattle ranches. But the land can only support cattle for a few years. Then the ranchers have to move on and clear another site.



LOGGING

Thousands of ebony, teak, and mahogany trees are cut down each year for export. People are now encouraged to buy furniture made of softwoods, such as pine, which take less time to regrow.

Plan of Bras lia



BRAS LIA

The city of Bras lia was built in the late 1950s as part of a government program to encourage people to move into the interior of the country. It became Brazil's capital in 1960, taking over from Rio de Janeiro. The city is laid out in the shape of an airplane, with the business district in the center, residential areas in the wings, and the government in the cockpit. Bold architecture, such as the glass cathedral shown here, is a feature of this modern city.



Find out more

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